

**Credibility in Online Tourism field.
An analysis of the aspects of reception and consumption of
imaginaries produced in Web 2.0 Tourism Services**

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Abstract

This research investigates the persuasiveness of the technological context of tourism social media websites, analysing the organization and layout of the elements displayed on a webpage, and their related perceived credibility. The aim is to understand which kinds of contextual elements are perceived as prominent and then recognized when browsing; and to understand tourists' perception, what is their attitude towards user generated contents and their related contextual elements. Findings show that freshness, debate, authority and agreement contextual dimensions are considered relevant by tourists who are browsing a tourism social media website.

Keywords: eTourism, web credibility, social media, web 2.0 tourism services.

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Introduction

The continuous development of Information and Communication Technologies (ICTs) during the last decades has had profound implications for the whole tourism industry (Buhalis, 2003); in particular on the way tourism goods are purchased, and the way by which travellers gather information and comment on their travel experience. Internet became crucial in the hospitality and tourism industry also because it offers new opportunities for promotion and marketing strategies for Destination Management Organizations (DMOs), which need to communicate with prospective travellers (Buhalis, 2003; Fesenmaier et al., 2010; Gretzel et al., 2006; Inversini et al., 2010; Marchiori et al., 2010, 2011). Not only the use of official/institutional websites is crucial for the online presence of tourism destinations, also the monitoring of the contributions produced by other users, named “user-generated contents” (UGCs) is an activity in which tourism destination managers are investing efforts to find strategies in order to analyze online unstructured data produced by travellers, which concur to form the eWord-of-Mouth (eWOM), and in order to integrate eWOM as part of the co-creation of tourism value.

eWOM takes place generally within Social Media websites, which allow users to easily upload and share contents such as texts, videos, photos. Social media websites, such as blogs, virtual communities, consumer review websites, social networks, are competing to reach end-users presenting almost the same information as the official websites do (Inversini and Buhalis, 2009). This ever-increasing web 2.0 phenomenon (O'Reilly, 2005) enables individual users to share knowledge and contributes significantly to the growth of information on the web (Cantoni and Tardini, 2010). With the new media, people become more aware of other people, places and events, sharing tourism imaginaries and giving to people and society an understanding of their place in the world (Salazar, 2007).

Scholars have studied the influence of social media on the decision making process of prospective travelers who use the web in order to search for information and purchase the next trip (Fesenmaier et al., 2010). Contents expressed online such as the value for money spent for a tourism product and service, and the satisfaction of the tourism experience, seem to be the most frequent topics published by tourists (Marchiori et al., 2011). Park and Gretzel (2007) studied which were the most studied factors in the tourism field for the evaluation of a web page. Results underlined how factors such as the information quality of the websites,

ease of use, responsiveness, security/privacy, visual appearance, trust, interactivity, personalization, and fulfilment, are the elements that should be taken into consideration for the analysis of websites' performance and persuasiveness in the hospitality and tourism field. Moreover, as in De Moor and Aakhus (2003), each technology has a technical functionality design – technological context – which consists of all functions that operate on the information objects that the technology can process, and this supports and may influence a wide range of argumentation behaviors.

This research would move beyond the analysis of websites' contents (topic and argument expressed), and investigate the persuasiveness of the technological context created by social media websites, extending the research on the visual appearance of the page and the related perceived credibility. According to Fogg (2001, 2003), not only the topics of a website are relevant for the decision-making process, but also the contextual elements, named “persuasive technology”, in which the contents are placed, e.g.: user profile, number of contributions, comments, number of replies, ranking, etc. All these contextual elements can influence in terms of credibility. Fogg (2001, 2003) further observed that in order to make use of a functionality, and therefore of a product, people first have considered this functionality to be credible. Credibility, in fact, is the most crucial factor within the persuasion concept, and drives this research; it can be defined as the capacity of an element to be noted and perceived as trustworthy for its expertise and less disposition to bias (Brown et. al., 2007). The main motivation to investigate this aspect is due to a lack of research on contextual elements in tourism social media websites. Evaluation of the content credibility is a fundamental component of the value of the eWOM network, and can influence the final judgment of a user. A user's knowledge of the web source is limited, and the trustworthiness evaluation of the page will take place using reduced- or altered cues. Thus, understanding the role of features characteristic of social media websites can benefit the analysis of the aspects of reception and consumption of imaginaries produced in web 2.0 tourism services. For instance, knowing that the author profile is not a relevant element on the consumption of the content, the analysis of this indicator could be weighed differently when it comes to evaluating the relevance of the content itself.

The aim of this research is to contribute to the analysis of the appearance of contextual elements and their credibility on tourism social media websites, in order to understand which kinds of elements are perceived as prominent and then recognized when browsing; and to understand tourists' attitude towards UGCs, and to know what are the contextual elements

tourists declare to consider more reliable while they are browsing a tourism social media website.

In order to answer to the main research question “what are the credibility factors that can influence the consumption of imaginaries published in web 2.0 tourism services?”, an analysis of the contents and functionalities offered by two web 2.0 tourism services has been done; then, a user testing of the same two websites has been performed, which has helped to identify the contextual elements that are perceived as credible by prospective travelers; finally, an extensive survey has been conducted to investigate which contextual elements are relevant when tourists are assessing the credibility of a web page.

Literature Review

This paragraph discusses the role of ICT in the Hospitality and Tourism industry, in particular the relevance of social media websites publishing contributions by users. In this context, the presence of the so-called eWOM will be investigated as the crucial driver for tourism imaginaries studies. Social media allow to host contributions of users and are nowadays the online spaces where information about destinations are mainly shared among users.

Tourism imaginaries and web 2.0

During the tourism consumer decision-making process, prospective consumers can access internet as a platform for information and recommendation seeking, as well as for booking (Fesenmaier et al., 2010). As in Dickinger et al. (2011), online contents presented on social media websites can be seen as public representations of the tourism destination produced by users and expressed in texts, and/or pictures, and/or videos (Mazanec and Wober, 2009). These mediated contents contribute to form the idea of a tourism destination that a prospective traveller builds in her/his mind, and may influence the decision to visit the place. As in Salazar (2007) these various online representations are part of an intricate system of artifacts and communication devices: brochures, guide books, novels, newspapers, television programs, movies, museums, student exchange programs, conferences, as well as the full range of internet sources. Thus, the analysis of the meaning expressed by UGCs represents a valuable source of information for the studies on tourism imaginaries production and consumption, on product performance, brand image, consumption experiences and the like, such an analysis may be able to inform marketing decisions as well as product development

(Dickinger et al., 2011). Anderson (1983), extending his consideration of nations as the result of “imagined communities”, argues that with new media people can become more aware of other people, places and events in their own nation. However, as argued by Salazar (2007), discursive imaginaries are spread in different times: before, during, and after the tourism experience, and places: at home, at the office, away; they are also spread in various modalities: oral, written, or graphic. Paying attention to the web as a communication channel, where narratives can contribute to tourism imaginaries about a place (Bruner, 2005; Salazar, 2007), all the aspects of the web are to be considered. Indeed, in the online environment, it must be considered that users might form their idea about a future vacation and/or about a destination from the contents presented online, which are based on relatively impersonal textual resources provided by other users (Brown et al., 2007).

Tourism Website evaluation measures

Website evaluation measures have been proposed in various contexts and fields as they are crucial for the understanding of the performance of online communication. This is particularly relevant in the hospitality and tourism field, where the massive use of internet by prospective travelers who need to search for information, inspiration and purchase for their next holidays, has open to better research the communication spread via web and the perceptions by users. Moreover, this research interest responds to an industry need to better understand how to act a persuasive communication between tourism players and prospective travelers. Destination Management Organizations (DMOs) need to create websites that can persuade travelers to visit their destination, and to satisfy information needs. However, tourism managers have to pay attention to other players in the web arena, such as the contents produced by social media users, which are concurring on co-creating imaginaries and tourism narratives about the same destination. Park and Gretzel (2007) analysed the commonly analysed/proposed success factors for the realization of successful tourism web sites. Nine factors are actually the main research topics in this field: (1) information quality; (2) ease of use; (3) responsiveness; (4) security/privacy; (5) visual appearance; (6) trust; (7) interactivity; (8) personalization; and (9) fulfilment. Scholars argue that the analysis of the website evaluation can provide benefits such as customer retention, positive return on investment, and leadership within the competition (Park and Gretzel, 2007). Even if the main focus of these studies is the content of the websites, and the overall evaluation of the browsing experience (Gretzel et al., 2006; Kim and Fesenmaier, 2008), an increasing attention is devoted to the

contextual elements present in tourism websites. Studies on destination websites' persuasiveness (Loda et al., 2009) underline the importance of message credibility, which can impact on the decision to visit a destination. Scholars underline how the first impression that a user has about a webpage is crucial in order to proceed or not with the reading of the contents (Li et al., 2009). As in Kim and Fesenmaier (2008), the perception of credibility of contextual elements can influence the decision to continue (or not) to visit a website. This decision is based primarily on visitors' overall impression toward the website, and on their perception of the site inspirational value, and these factors are closely followed in importance by involvement, and by destination knowledge.

Credibility in Social Media Tourism websites

Fogg (2001, 2003) and others (Gretzel et al., 2006, 2008; Kim and Fesenmaier, 2008; Xiang et al., 2008) argue that the internet is a particularly effective communication medium to persuade people. This is particularly true in the online tourism domain (Kim and Fesenmaier, 2008), where the messages found online, sent by institutional or non-institutional websites (senders), represent a mediated experience for a prospective traveller or tourism player (receivers), who would like to collect information about a tourism destination. The way in which the message is presented, along with its context, can play a role in persuading people during their decision-making process to visit a given destination.

We can apply Jakobson's communication model (Jakobson, 1960) to the tourism domain. The basic concept of Jakobson's model is that communication entails six factors: addresser, message, addressee, context, code, and contact (see Table n. 1). These factors are also present in the online tourism domain as a space where communication is shaped and takes place:

Jakobson's Communication Model	Factors description	Online Tourism Domain Application
<i>addresser:</i>	who sends a message	the website owner or the user who posts a message (can be an institutional, non-institutional source). In the online environment it is possible to identify multi-senders
<i>message:</i>	the information sent by the addresser	the information published online, and the physical characteristics of the page within which the message is published
<i>addressee:</i>	to whom the message is delivered	the person who accesses the message (can be a prospect traveller or someone else). In the online environment there are multi-receivers
<i>context:</i>	the general environment to which the message refers to, or within it exists	the tourism destination itself and the online tourism domain
<i>code:</i>	the semiotic code through which the 'addresser' and the 'addressee'	text, video, photo, audio...

	communicate	
<i>contact:</i>	The channel between the addresser and the addressee, enabling them to enter and stay in communication	the web itself, a specific online service

Table 1: Application of Jakobson's Communication Model (1960) to the Tourism domain

The message presented online contains online representations/image projections about a tourism destination (Govers and Go, 2005; 2009), and the analysis of such online representations is the main interest of this research. According to a recent study from Li, Pan, and Zhang (2009), a prospective traveller is influenced by the affective components expressed on social media website, for example: declaration of the experience satisfaction, hotel-restaurants' reviews, recommendation of what to do once arrived at the destination. An analysis by Nielsen Global Online Consumer Survey (April, 2009) studied the degree of trust in several forms of advertising, e.g. from television, radio, online, newspaper: "consumer opinions posted online" were perceived as trustworthy by 70% of respondents, while "recommendations from people known" got 90%, and "brand websites" got 70%. Therefore, social media websites were perceived as equally trustworthy as official websites.

Results from Brown et al. (2007), show how website factors, such as possession of greater expertise and less disposition to bias, assumed a predominant role in individuals' evaluation of source credibility. Besides the trustworthiness of content, it is important to consider that there are several other variables that play a role in the decision making, such as motivation of prospective travelers, their travel experiences, socio-demographic and personal characteristics (Beerli and Martin, 2004). As in Brown et al. (2007), in the online environment, such evaluations must be made from the relatively impersonal text-based resource exchange done by actors in the network.

According to Fogg (2001, 2003), contextual elements, named "persuasive technologies", in which the contents are placed, are relevant factors to be taken into account when analyzing how websites influence decision making; contextual elements in a social media website are, for instance: user profile, number of contributions by a given person, comments, number of replies, ranking. Kim and Fesenmaier (2007) have studied this within the tourism field, showing how users were able to make quick judgments on tourism websites: inspiration and usability were the primary drivers evoking a favorable first impression.

In order to investigate the website elements that help to reach an overall credibility assessment, Fogg (2003) developed the construct of Web Credibility: Prominence-

Interpretation Theory, which argues that a content in order to be perceived as credible needs to be noted, and then interpreted considering the following variables:

1. Involvement of the user (i.e., the motivation and ability to scrutinize website content)
 2. Topic of the website (e.g., news, entertainment)
 3. Task of the user (e.g., seeking information, seeking amusement, making a transaction)
 4. Experience of the user (e.g., novice vs. expert in regard to subject matter or web conventions)
 5. Individual differences (e.g., a person's need for cognition, learning style, or literacy level)
- (source: Fogg, 2003)

This study will use the concept of prominence in order to identify the indicators that are more likely to be perceived as credible in tourism social media websites.

Research Design

This paragraph outlines the research design, data collection and data analysis.

The study has been performed following three steps:

- a. *Content and functionalities analysis* of social media tourism websites, in order to find and categorize their types of contents and functionalities, which are more likely to be perceived as prominent and credible by users.
- b. *User testing*: in order to understand which kinds of contextual elements are more likely to play a role in users' decision making.
- c. *Survey*: in order to understand what is tourists' attitude towards UGCs; and what are the contextual elements which they consider more reliable while browsing a tourism social media website.

Content and functionalities analysis

Two web2.0 tourism related websites have been analyzed via an expert inspection, in order to list their contents and functionalities' types. The selected tourism social media websites were the following ones:

- Tripadvisor (www.tripadvisor.com), one of the most known websites publishing consumer reviews in the hospitality and tourism field. Tripadvisor is mostly based on UGCs.
- Lonely Planet (www.lonelyplanet.com), one of the most famous websites offering tourism guides. In this website contents are mainly produced by experts – like in printed tourism guides – but it offers also an area where users can publish their experiences and comments.

These two websites share the goal to be informative, and to suggest trips to prospective travellers. The classification of the contents and functionalities enabled to identify common indicators offered by them. The analysis was performed according to the semantic narrative categories and subcategories grid by Cantoni et al. (2007), where the minimal element(/indicator) is represented by a type of content or functionality. Types of contents and functionalities related to UGCs present in both the websites, and used for the user testing tasks are listed in Table 2.

Tripadvisor	Lonely Planet
Rate Review	Ask a question
Upload photo/video	Participate to the forum discussion
Write a review (about hotels, restaurants, activities)	Leave Posts
Leave a comment	Create your Blog
Add the trip (forum)	Subscribe to other Blogs
Rate the replies (forum)	Subscribe to the Blog feed
Add new topic (forum)	Add a comment/reply
Rate the destination	Report a comment/abuse
Choose the member you want to advice	Associate a content with a tag
Newsletter subscription	Write a review about (itineraries, flights, hotels)
Appreciate the content using “I like” (link to Facebook)	Write a review about accomodation/restaurants
Add profile info (country, language, photo, contact)	Inform if the details are incorrect (about hotels/restaurants)
	Newsletter subscription
	Appreciate the content using “I like” (link to Facebook)
	Add profile info (country, language, photo, contact)

Table 2. UGCs related type of contents and functionalities in Tripadvisor and LonelyPlanet

These activities are displayed according to different layouts (see Figure 1). A logged-in user can publish/interact on the website using the elements present in Table 2, and a non logged-in user can just view the contributions of other users, and do some limited activities.

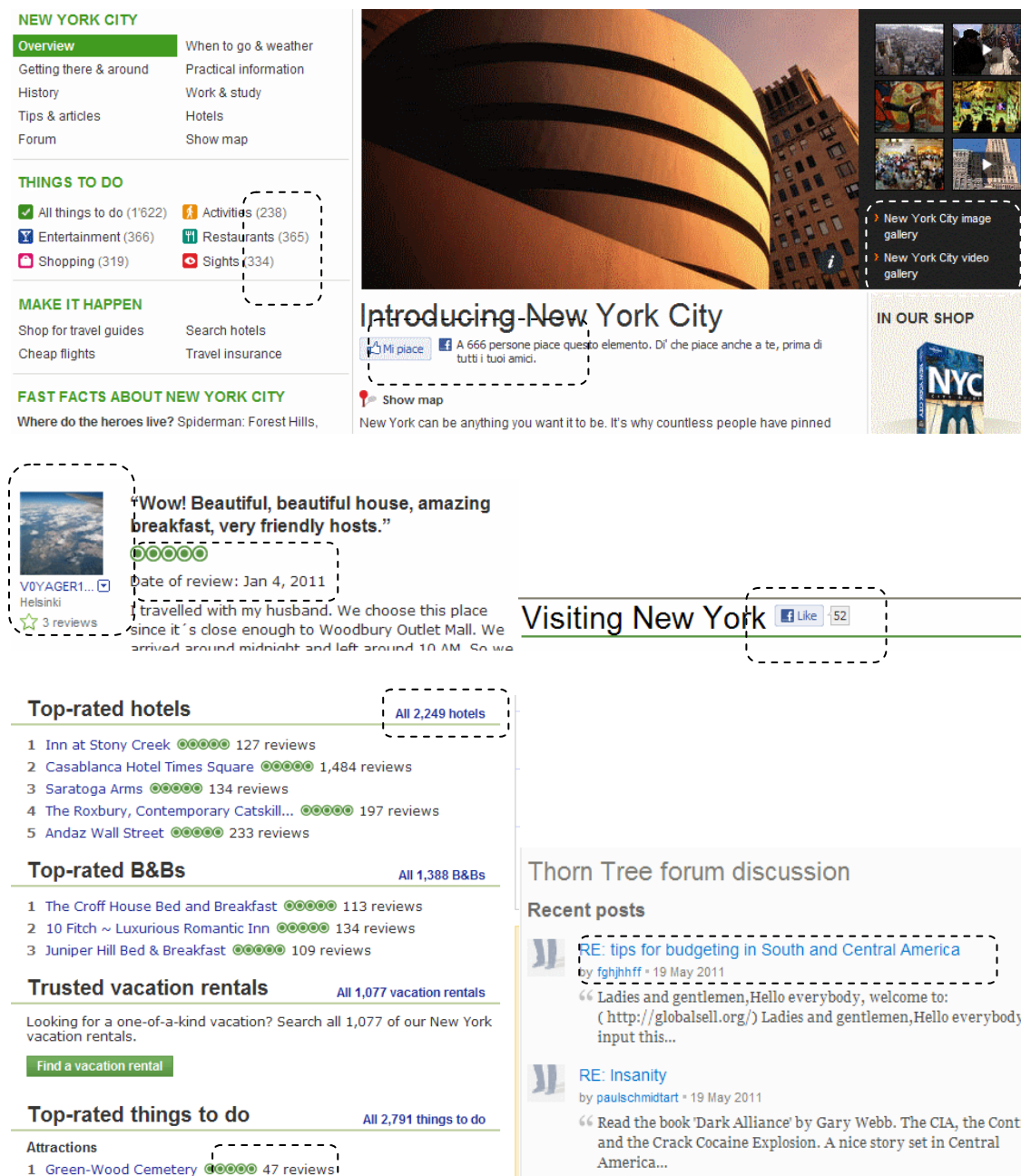


Figure 1: Examples of UGCs contextual elements in LonelyPlanet and Tripadvisor.

User testing

In order to understand whether or not UGC contextual elements influence the decision making process of a prospect traveler, a user testing was performed.

A sample of 9 students and a professor, between 23-45 years old, was chosen. They have been requested to navigate on both websites performing a commons scenario, verbalizing their thoughts, so to track which elements were noticed (= prominent) and perceived as credible by them.

The user testing was structured using the following scenario: *suppose you want to go to N.Y. You have a budget of 3,000 CHF for the accommodation for 7 days of holiday.*

Users were asked to:

- i. browse the Destination Offers section of the two websites, in order to find the best relevant offer.
- ii. browse the Destination Description section of the two websites, in order to be inspired.
- iii. browse the authors of the tips/reviews section of the two websites, in order to identify the most credible, in order to identify the most credible ones.

Survey

Having obtained the list of contextual indicators of tourism social media websites perceived as more prominent and credible by prospective travellers, an extensive survey was conducted in order to verify whether travellers consider these indicators while they are using web2.0 websites for their travel information seeking.

In particular, survey's goals were to:

- understand, their trust/attitude towards UGCs
- rank contextual elements that tourists declare to consider more reliable when they are using a tourism social media website

The survey studied people who travel for leisure, and was conducted at two Italian airports: Milan Malpensa and Milan Linate. A total of 502 responses were collected, 485 of them could be used. The collection has been carried out from the 6th to the 23rd August 2010.

Results

User testing results suggested to group contextual elements presented in Table 2 into the following four areas:

1. *Freshness*: users declare to be more affected by comments and/or replies when they are recent. The availability of the date seems to be crucial in order to assess the credibility of a content presented in a page.
2. *Debate*: users declare to be more affected by contents that have an high number of replies. This seems to be particular crucial when a user is browsing for getting inspiration. Involved services/contextual elements are: ask a question, participate to

forum discussion, leave posts, comments, reply, review, report comment/abuse, add a new topic, upload photo-video.

3. *Authority*: users do not seem to be affected by the user profile.
4. *Agreement*: users are more affected by the contents of the page if they present other users' approval, e.g.: mark the content using "i like" (link to Facebook), inform if the details are incorrect (about hotels/restaurants); rate the destination.

During the test, users tended to underline mainly elements disturbing their browsing process, more than stressing the ones that increase the credibility of the page.

Findings obtained during user testing tasks can be grouped as follows.

Credibility assessment while finding the best trip offer

Users stressed the role played by the number of comments and/or replies while looking for the best trip offer. Date availability of comments seemed to be crucial in order to notice them and to assess their credibility.

Credibility assessment while looking for trip inspiration

Users stressed the importance of the number of other users' approval and the information about their authors. The freshness of UGCs seemed to be crucial in order to pay attention to comments and assess their credibility.

Credibility assessment considering user profile info of UGCs' authors

Users stressed the importance to see the information of the profile of the author of the comment.

The four credibility indicators Freshness, Debate, Authority, and Agreement, were then presented to tourists in order to investigate if they consider them as relevant when assessing the credibility of a social media website. Among the 485 valid surveys, sex was balanced with 53.5% of female respondents and 46.5% male, with an age range of 18-29 (58,5%); 30-49 (39,0%); and 50+ (2,5%). Respondents were mainly from Italy (84.3%), while the rest were spread among 25 more countries, such as UK (3.3%), Australia (1.9%), France, and US (both 1.4%).

The majority of the respondents (92.1%) declare to use other tourists' contents, either on purpose or because they just found them when searching for information. Only 2.7% of the

respondents were not able to distinguish tourists' generated resources from the whole contents available online, and the 5.3% declared not to use UGCs at all.

Moreover, respondents declared to be influenced by UGCs produced by other tourists: 61.7% of the interviewees stated that UGCs somehow or highly influence their decision-making process while choosing a destination. The remaining 38.3% were low influenced or not influenced at all by UGCs. Moreover, respondents considered the contents produced by other tourists as trustworthy: when asked to rate their trust towards UGC, only 19.2% of interviewees declared to have low or very low trust; and 26% of respondents have high or very high trust towards UGC.

Tourist's considerations towards social media contextual elements

Respondents were asked to assess their position about the relevance of contextual information, considering freshness, debate, authority and agreement factors. Since the question was structured as a Likert scale, where the value 1 was 'not important at all' and 5 was 'very important', results show how the availability of updated comments or replies (=freshness) was the most important motivation in order to consider a UGC content credible. Thus, it was possible to rank the contextual elements as follows (see Table 3).

Contextual element	Description	Mean	St. Dev.
1. Freshness	Comments and/or replies are up to date	3.48	1.15
2. Debate	High number of replies	3.32	1.23
3. Authority	Author of the comment profile	3.22	1.13
4. Agreement	Other user's approval	2.65	1.26

Table 3: Contextual elements ranked by tourists. Likert scale (1 = 'not important at all' ; 5 = 'very important')

Conclusions

The main objective of this research was to investigate the presence of contextual elements on tourism social media websites, and to find out which are more likely to be perceived as credible by tourists. Following Jakobson's communication model, it is possible to claim that the *message*, the information published online, need to be studied along the physical characteristics of the page where it is published. The *addressers*, who sends the message, should is judged according to the four contextual dimensions of: freshness, debate, authority

and agreement. In particular, the *addressee*, the person who accesses the message, seems to evaluate the relevance of the page mainly based on the freshness dimension: websites' sections with not up-to-date contents or few rates are perceived as not so relevant.

The four contextual dimensions identified can be displayed in different graphical form, and connected usability issues can affect the browsing experience of the websites. Thus, these elements can be perceived as trustworthy if their navigation is user friendly. This result is indicative of how contextual elements' can potentially distract and change the overall evaluation of a content presented on a page.

In the user testing, the tendency to mention mainly signals which decrease the credibility while browsing the studied websites was consistent among the users. Therefore this research confirmed that the content of the page should be analyzed and weighted considering the contextual elements within which it is displayed, this is in line with argumentation design studies (De Moor and Aakhus, 2003).

Moreover, this research shows how content's author is not so relevant for website's users.

Researchers who want to select online data for content analysis should take into consideration, while selecting their sample, the four contextual dimensions of freshness, debate, authority and agreement, in order to avoid potentially biased results.

Future works in the field of websites' evaluation and web credibility should consider: (i) to do user testing with real tourists, and to increase the number of the people in the sample itself; (ii) to observe the attitude of the users towards the whole website (both content and contextual elements) with respect to the trip decision making.

Coming to practical implications: the study can be useful for tourism social media designers, who are designing the information architecture of their websites, and for all DMO's managers, who need to weight the contents posted within specific websites sections.

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